

# YOUTUBE'S BIG INDIA BET

## INDIA'S CREATOR ECONOMY

## IS A BUSINESS ENGINE

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India's creator economy is no longer just of cultural significance. What's unfolding is a shift from content creation to "contentpreneurship," where creators are building businesses, teams, and global audiences, emphasises Gunjan Soni, Managing Director - India, YouTube. With millions entering the ecosystem and platforms evolving into full-stack infrastructure, YouTube sees itself not just as a stage, but as the backbone of a decentralized, creator-led digital economy reshaping how India works and expresses itself.

### What do most people not know about YouTube's creator economy in India?

What we're seeing today on YouTube is a fundamental cultural and entrepreneurial shift. The sheer scale of ambition is amazing: 83% of Indian GenZ now consider themselves content creators. And, the impact of this is undeniable: according to Oxford Economics research, this ecosystem contributed ₹16,000 crore to India's GDP and supported 930,000 full-time equivalent jobs in 2024. We're seeing a decentralized, creator-led economy that is becoming a core pillar of India's digital future. The story isn't just about cultural influence; it's about a fundamental re-imagining of what a career path

can look like in modern India.

### What changes have you seen in YouTube and the creator universe in India?

The most satisfying shift I've witnessed is the rise of the 'Contentpreneur'. Creators are now operating as full-fledged, next-gen media studios. My greatest satisfaction comes from seeing our 'multi-format flywheel' in action, because it's the engine powering this entire transformation.

A creator can find their first audience among our 650 million monthly Shorts users in India. That's the handshake. Then, they deepen that relationship with long-form video, building a loyal community that increasingly watches on the living room screen - our Connected TV audience of 75 million is our fastest-growing surface. This is where they build durable IP. With 15% of watch time on content produced in India now coming from outside our borders, our creators are emerging as global icons. Witnessing that journey is my biggest highlight.

### How is YouTube looking at AI?

We approach AI with a dual mission: to empower creativity and to protect the creators who drive it.



**Gunjan Soni**  
Managing Director  
- India, YouTube

To protect, we are deploying AI as a shield. Our content moderation systems enforce our Community Guidelines at scale, and with new tools like Likeness Detection, we are giving creators the power to control their digital identity. To

empower, we are using AI to solve real-world creative hurdles, from using AI-powered auto-dubbing to help a creator in Marathi instantly reach an audience in Spanish, to using Edit with AI to automate the technical 'grind' of editing.

Our guidance for creators is to view these tools, like Google's Veo and Flow, as a way to narrow the gap between an idea and its execution, allowing them to focus on the human and emotional core of their stories. While AI is a powerful force multiplier for growth and localization, the creator's authentic voice and trust they build with their community remains irreplaceable.

### What's your message to anyone in India who wants to become a creator?

Shift your mindset from being a 'content creator' to becoming a 'Contentpreneur.' First, build on trust, because fandom is the new currency. An incredible 85% of viewers trust recommendations from their favorite creators more than traditional ads. That trust is your foundation, so protect it. Second, embrace the full canvas. Don't limit yourself to one format. Use Shorts to find your audience, use long-form to build a community, and use Live to forge a direct, unbreakable bond. Finally, think of yourself as a CEO from day one. The tools are here, the audience is waiting, and the opportunity has never been greater. **d**